

BarberRepublic

EARN . LIVE . THRIVE | The labour exchange platform for the barbering industry

Introduction for Haatch | Submitted via introduction from Graham Byrne | Prepared by John Webb O'Rourke, Commercial Lead | July 2026
| Confidential

The Problem

The UK barbering industry is worth over £1 billion a year, and it runs on a structural inefficiency nobody has solved. Every barbershop is two barbers away from serious trouble. A holiday, a sick day, or a barber simply taking a day off means empty chairs and lost revenue that cannot be recovered.

At the same time, many self-employed and contract barbers experience quieter trading days. As consumer behaviour continues to change, peak trading days differ from one shop to another, creating unused capacity in some locations while others struggle to meet demand.

BarberRepublic bridges that gap by allowing skilled barbers to move between locations, helping shop owners maximise revenue while giving barbers the opportunity to earn more consistently throughout the month.

The Solution

BarberRepublic is the labour exchange platform for the barbering industry. Barbers post their available days and day rate. Shops post their open chairs. The platform intelligently matches them in minutes. Both sides confirm, the barber shows up, the work gets done, payment goes through the app. Both sides rate the experience. Simple. Fast. Done.

The platform is AI-native by design — intelligent matching, demand prediction and platform learning are architected in from the ground up under the direction of our Chief Technical Lead, Shane McCarthy, so the system gets smarter with every booking and builds a proprietary data layer from the first transaction. Four skill tiers — Barber (£120+) through Super Pro Hair (£180+) — ensure every barber earns at their level; emergency cover commands a surge premium.

Keeping bookings on-platform: the retention mechanic is guarantee, not lock-in. The barber gets guaranteed work and in-app payment; the shop gets verified, reliable cover and a rated pool; disputes and no-shows are the platform's problem, not theirs. Set against those guarantees, the saving from going direct is marginal — and the risk moves back onto the shop.

Market and Validation

The UK barbering market exceeds £1 billion in annual revenue. In summer 2026 OpenChair launched publicly in the United States — a chair-rental app for barbers and stylists. It is an adjacent model rather than a direct comparable, but its rapid adoption signals real appetite for real-time barber-and-chair matching. No equivalent UK labour exchange platform exists. The first mover window is open now.

Closer to home, the founder has been in direct contact with experienced operators across London barbershops, and the response has been consistently positive. These are the people who feel the cover problem weekly, and they are signalling clear demand for exactly this platform. A founding-cohort Letters of Intent programme is in progress off the back of that outreach.

Unit Economics

Barber: two platform shifts a week at an average £180 per shift is roughly £1,440 gross a month in incremental income; established barbers can condense their client base into three days and free two days for platform work. **Shop:** emergency cover at circa £250 a shift protects a fully booked day worth circa £550 — cover is a revenue-protection decision, not a cost centre. **Platform:** at an illustrative 12-15% commission on current day rates, monthly break-even sits at roughly 900-1,500 bookings, a bottom-up target the London launch is scoped to prove.

Business Model

Commission on cover bookings is the wedge from day one. Everything else is phased roadmap once the core loop is proven.

Revenue Stream	Description	Timing
Commission	Percentage of every booking — payable by the shop	From day one

Membership	Monthly subscriptions for barbers and shops — enhanced features and priority matching	From Month 3
Advertising	Premium barbering brands advertising to a captive professional audience in-app	Year 2 onwards
Education	Academies and educators listed and booked through the platform, commission per booking	Year 2 onwards

Progress to Date

- Platform concept fully developed and documented; app mockup completed across seven screens.
- AI-native architecture designed by the Chief Technical Lead; MVP specification locked, targeted at 90 days from funding confirmation.
- Founding cohort outreach under way, led personally by the founder, with consistently positive responses; signed Letters of Intent being gathered towards 30 barbers and 15 shops for the London launch.
- In early conversation with a London-based consumer and retail VC following a warm introduction.
- Rebrand from BarberTemp to BarberRepublic under way; domain secured, formal IP protection in progress; platform T&Cs, barber and shop contracts in development, with employment-agency status and worker classification under legal review before build.

The Team

Role	Background
Johnny Shanahan — Founder & Managing Director (full time from funding)	25 years as a master barber. Founder of BarberBarberUK, Manchester. Personal network across the UK, US, Australia and Japan. Trusted at the highest level of the industry. Leading the founding barber and shop recruitment personally and running the business day to day from funding.
John Webb O'Rourke — Commercial Lead (advisory)	40 years across law, finance, property and entrepreneurship. Commercial strategy, investor relations, legal and governance.
Shane McCarthy — Chief Technical Lead	AI systems architect. Designed the full AI-native platform architecture; MVP specification locked. Build delivered by a contracted technical team under his direction.
Operations — COO hire	London-based, full time from Month 2. Onboarding, barber and shop management.

The Raise

Item	Figure	Notes
Minimum raise	£500,000	Covers Year 1 fully with runway into Year 2.
Target raise	£600k–£750k	Full Year 2 runway. No second raise before traction is confirmed.
Year 1 costs	£350,000	MD salary, COO, tech build, legal, office, launch. Zero Year 1 revenue assumed.
Revenue starts	Month 5–6	Commission from founding cohort. London only.
Break-even	Month 20–24	Target, presented with sensitivities in the full model (booking growth, take rate, leakage).
Year 5 ambition	£100m–£150m	Planning ambition grounded in standard marketplace comparables, not a projection.

BarberRepublic is raising a minimum of £500,000 to build an AI-native platform in a validated market with a founder the industry already trusts. Year 1 is treated as fully at risk with zero revenue assumed — a deliberately conservative basis. The target raise of £600,000 to £750,000 removes the pressure of a second raise before London traction is firmly established and gives the business the best chance of reaching break-even on its own terms. The near-term investment case rests on London proof of concept and the Stage 2 raise from demonstrated traction, not on the long-range ambition.

Expansion Roadmap

Phase	Period	Geography	Objective
1 — Proof of Concept	Months 1–6	London	30 barbers, 15 shops, first 100 bookings. Unit economics confirmed.
2 — UK Roll-Out	Months 7–18	Manchester, Birmingham, Leeds, Glasgow	Stage 2 raise from London traction. Head of Growth hired.
3 — Ireland	Months 18–24	Dublin	Second jurisdiction. Enterprise Ireland routes open.
4 — International	Years 3–4	Australia, US, Japan	Founder's existing network. Series A raise.

Why Haatch

Haatch backs AI-driven businesses at the earliest stage, and BarberRepublic is AI-native at its core — the intelligence layer is the product, not a feature. The raise sits within Haatch's cheque size, the market signal is real, and the founding team combines deep industry authority with dedicated AI architecture leadership. We would welcome the opportunity to take Haatch through the full model and answer any questions directly.

Contact: Johnny Shanahan, Founder | Introduction via Graham Byrne.

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Planning estimates throughout; full financial model available on request. | Page 2 of 2